perhaps possessed all these years but did not have the courage to disclose.

I think the appointment of a truth commission, or more appropriately a truth and reconciliation commission (TRC), as was done in the case of South Africa, though on a much smaller scale, would help bring closure to this sordid episode and also pull the rug from under the feet of anti-India forces that are taking advantage of these unresolved issues.

It is widely accepted that a truth commission (i) is focused on the past, rather than on ongoing events; (ii) investigates a pattern of events that took place over a period of time; (iii) engages directly and broadly with the affected population, gathering information on their experiences; (iv) is a temporary body, with the aim of concluding with a final report; and (v) is officially authorized or empowered by the state to carry out the assigned task.

A TRC would have to be established in India through an Act of parliament or an ordnance followed by an Act. It should be headed by a retired chief justice of the Supreme Court of India, with two sitting or retired judges of the Supreme Court as its members. I am sure India has at least three such persons of unimpeachable integrity who are willing to perform their duty as a service to the nation without any expectation of being compensated for it.

Their time-bound mandate could include the following: Was there any genuine demand for Khalistan in Punjab before 1980? If so, how many people believed in that concept at that time? If not, who were the persons responsible for the seeding of such a demand and what were the reasons thereof? Why did so many rounds of negotiations between the government and Akali leaders fail to produce any result, which could have put an end to extremist activities in Punjab? Why were softer options to capture Bhindranwale from the Golden Temple complex rejected?

Was Operation Blue Star the only solution to restore peace in Punjab? How many people actually died in Operation Blue Star? Have all the people in the Golden Temple complex and the adjacent guesthouses and offices of the SGPC present on the premises on the eve of Blue Star been accounted for? Were Bhindranwale and his two associates, Amrik Singh and Thara Singh, captured alive and